

66 Abigail

The wise woman who stepped between an angry David and a bloodbath.

Abigail was the wife of Nabal, a rich and harsh sheep owner in Judah. David's men had protected Nabal's shepherds, but when David asked for food at shearing time, Nabal insulted him, and David set out with four hundred men to kill every male in the household. Without telling her husband, Abigail loaded donkeys with food, rode out to meet David, and bowed at his feet. Her humble, wise words turned him from revenge. After Nabal died, David married her. She shows how a gentle answer can turn away great harm.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Avigayil</i> , usually explained as "my father is joy"
Home	Maon, with Nabal's business in Carmel (1 Samuel 25:2)
Husbands	Nabal of the house of Caleb; later David (1 Samuel 25:3, 39–42)
Son	Chileab, or Daniel (2 Samuel 3:3; 1 Chronicles 3:1)
When	Saul's last years, before c. 1010 BC
Key people	Nabal, David, a young servant of Nabal
New Testament	Not named

"And blessed be thy advice, and blessed be thou, which hast kept me this day from coming to shed blood, and from avenging myself with mine own hand."

1 Samuel 25:33, KJV

The life of Abigail

Scripture gives no dates or ages for Abigail. These events happened after Samuel's death, while David was a fugitive from Saul (before c. 1010 BC).

Before the story	● Married to Nabal She is "of good understanding, and of a beautiful countenance." Her husband is rich, with three thousand sheep and a thousand goats, but "churlish and evil in his doings." <i>1 Samuel 25:2-3</i>
Sheep-shearing	● Warned by a servant Nabal refuses David's request and insults him. A young man tells Abigail that David's men had been "a wall unto us both by night and day," and that trouble is coming. <i>1 Samuel 25:4-17</i>
That day	● Rides out to David She loads donkeys with bread, wine, sheep, grain, raisins and figs. She meets David on the way, bows to the ground, and speaks for peace. David blesses God for sending her. <i>1 Samuel 25:18-35</i>
Ten days later	● Widowed When she tells Nabal the next morning, "his heart died within him." About ten days later the LORD strikes him, and he dies. <i>1 Samuel 25:36-38</i>
Soon after	● Marries David David hears that Nabal is dead and blesses the LORD. He sends servants to ask for Abigail as his wife. She bows, rises quickly, and goes with five maidens to become his wife. <i>1 Samuel 25:39-42</i>
At Ziklag and Hebron	● Captured, rescued, settled Amalekites carry her off from Ziklag, and David rescues her. Later she lives with David in Hebron, where she bears his son Chileab. <i>1 Samuel 30:1-18; 2 Samuel 2:2; 3:3</i>

Key activities

Abigail's speech (1 Samuel 25:24–31) is one of the longest speeches by a woman in the Old Testament. She takes the blame on herself, calls Nabal a fool, and speaks of the "sure house" God will give David.

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- 1 Listened to a servant.** When a young servant warned her, she took him seriously and acted at once. *1 Samuel 25:14–18*
 - 2 Acted quickly and generously.** She "made haste" and sent ahead two hundred loaves, five dressed sheep and other food. *1 Samuel 25:18–19*
 - 3 Humbled herself.** She fell at David's feet and said, "Upon me, my lord, upon me let this iniquity be." *1 Samuel 25:23–24*
 - 4 Told the truth about Nabal.** "As his name is, so is he; Nabal is his name, and folly is with him." *1 Samuel 25:25*
 - 5 Reminded David of God's plan.** She said the LORD would make David a sure house and that he should not carry the grief of needless bloodshed. *1 Samuel 25:28–31*
 - 6 Waited for the right time.** She did not speak to Nabal while he was drunk at his feast, but told him in the morning. *1 Samuel 25:36–37*
 - 7 Accepted a new life.** She answered David's proposal humbly and went with his servants. *1 Samuel 25:40–42*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Abigail.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 25	The main account
1 Samuel 27:3; 30:5, 18	With David among the Philistines; rescued at Ziklag
2 Samuel 2:2; 3:3	At Hebron she bears Chileab
1 Chronicles 2:16–17	A different Abigail, David's sister
Echo: Proverbs 15:1	"A soft answer turneth away wrath"
Echo: Deuteronomy 32:35	"To me belongeth vengeance"

New Testament

Echo: Matthew 5:9	"Blessed are the peacemakers"
Echo: Romans 12:19	"Avenge not yourselves"
Echo: James 3:17	Wisdom from above is "peaceable, gentle"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Abigail do and say when she met David (1 Samuel 25:18–31)?
2. *Understand:* David was about to do something terrible. Why did Abigail's words work when Nabal's words had made things worse?
3. *Apply:* Abigail stepped into a conflict that was not her fault. Is there a conflict around you where you could be a peacemaker this week?
4. *Apply:* David thanked God for someone who stopped him. Who has the freedom to tell you when you are about to make a mistake?